



Heracles

Hercules' harsh labors assure his fame.

—BOETHIUS, *Consolation of Philosophy*, 4.7.13

HERACLES IS THE GREATEST of the Greek heroes. His legends include elements of saga and folktale,¹ while his status as man, hero, and god is controversial. In Greece, he was particularly associated with the area around Argos, with Thebes (the city of his birth), and with Trachis and **Mt. Oeta** in southern Thessaly (the place of his death and apotheosis).

Amphitryon and Alcmena

The father of Heracles was Amphitryon, son of Alcaeus and brother of the king of Mycenae, **Electryon**, whose daughter, Alcmena, became his wife. After Amphitryon accidentally killed Electryon, as punishment Amphitryon was exiled from Mycenae and came to Thebes, taking Alcmena with him. There he was purified by the Theban king, Creon, and set out to campaign against the Teleboans, a people of western Greece, who had attacked Electryon in Mycenae and killed all but one of his sons.² The expedition was successful through the treachery of Comaetho, daughter of the Teleboan king Pterelaüs. Out of love for Amphitryon she pulled from Pterelaüs' head the golden hair that guaranteed him immortality and made the Teleboans invincible.

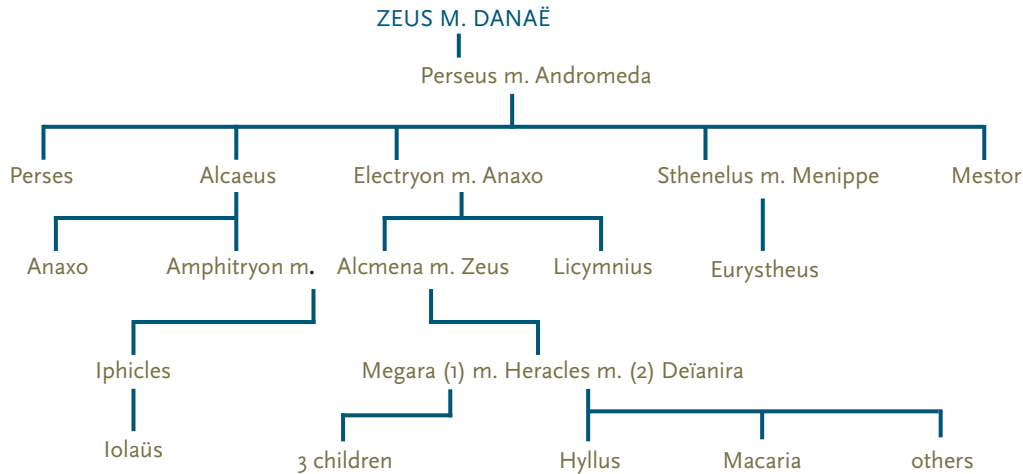


Figure 22.1 The Ancestry of Heracles

Thus Pterelaüs died and Amphitryon was victorious. Amphitryon killed Co-maetho and returned to Thebes.³

Amphitryon expected to lie with Alcmena, and he did not know that Zeus, disguised as Amphitryon, had visited her the previous night, which he extended to three times its proper length, and had told her the full story of the Teleboan expedition. Alcmena only accepted Amphitryon after Tiresias had revealed the truth. Thus Amphitryon lay “all night long with his chaste wife, delighting in the gifts of golden Aphrodite” (Hesiod, *Shield of Heracles*, 46–47). Alcmena conceived twins (it was said); the elder by one night was Heracles, son of Zeus, and the younger was Iphicles, son of Amphitryon.

In the *Amphitruo* of the Roman dramatist Plautus, Jupiter (Zeus) and Mercury (Hermes) disguise themselves as Amphitryon and Amphitryon’s servant Sosia, respectively. Amphitryon returns just after Jupiter has left Alcmena, who is thoroughly confused. She gives birth to twins, one of whom is stronger than the other and immediately strangles two serpents sent by Juno (Hera) to kill him. Just as Alcmena’s servant Bromia is describing the scene, Jupiter himself appears and reveals the truth to Amphitryon. This is the only one of Plautus’ surviving plays whose plot is taken from mythology.

The Birth of Heracles and His Early Exploits

The birth of Heracles introduces a constant feature of his story: the hostility of Hera. On the day when Heracles was to be born, Zeus had boasted on Olympus (Homer, *Iliad* 19. 103–105):

Today Eileithyia, helper in childbirth, will bring to the light a man who shall rule over all that dwell around him; he shall be of the race that is of my blood.

Hera deceived Zeus by hastening the birth of the child of Sthenelus (king of Mycenae), whose wife was seven months pregnant, and sending Eileithyia

to delay the birth of Alcmena's sons.⁴ Sthenelus was the grandson of Zeus, and so his son rather than Alcmena's fulfilled the terms of Zeus' boast. He was **Eurystheus**, for whom Heracles performed the Labors.

Pindar tells the story (mentioned earlier in connection with the *Amphitruo* of Plautus) that Hera also sent a pair of snakes to kill the infant Heracles, whose birth she had not been able to prevent. The passage ends with the prophet Tiresias foretelling the hero's part in the battle of the gods against the Giants and his eventual deification (*Nemean Odes* 1. 33–72):



Audio

Willingly do I take hold of Heracles upon the high peaks of Virtue as I retell an ancient tale. When the son of Zeus had escaped from the birth pangs with his twin and had come into the bright light, he was wrapped in the yellow swaddling bands, and Hera of the golden throne saw him. Straightway in hasty anger, the queen of the gods sent snakes, which passed through the open doors into the farthest part of the wide room, eager to coil their quick jaws around the children. But Heracles lifted up his head and for the first time made trial of battle; with his two hands, from which there was no escape, he seized by their necks the two serpents, and his grip squeezed the life out of the huge monsters, strangling them. (33–47)

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Then fear unbearable struck the women who were helping Alcmena at the birth. Alcmena, too, leaped to her feet from the bedclothes, unclothed as she was, as if to protect her babies from the attack of the beasts. Then the Theban leaders quickly ran and assembled with their bronze weapons, and Amphitryon came, smitten with the bitter pangs of anxiety and brandishing his sword unsheathed. . . . He stood with amazement hard to bear mixed with joy, for he saw the immeasurable spirit and power of his son. The immortals indeed had made the words of the messengers untrue. Then he summoned Tiresias, his neighbor, excellent mouthpiece of Zeus the most high. To Amphitryon and to all his armed men he foretold with what fortunes Heracles would meet, how many lawless wild beasts he would kill on the sea, how many on land. He foretold how Heracles would give to his fate the man who walks with crooked insolence, most hateful of men. For, he foretold, when the gods should do battle with the giants on the plain of Phlegra, beneath the onrush of his missiles, bright hair would be soiled in the dust. But Heracles himself, in peace for all time without end, would win rest as the choice reward for his great labors, and in the palaces of the blessed he would take Hebe to be his youthful bride. Feasting at his wedding beside Zeus, son of Cronus, he would praise the holy customs of the gods. (48–72)

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Thus Heracles survived. In his education, he was taught chariot driving by Amphitryon, wrestling by Autolycus, archery by Eurytus, and music by Linus.⁵ Heracles killed Linus, who was a son of Apollo, by striking him with his lyre, and for this was sent away to the Theban pastures on Mt. Cithaeron, where he performed a number of exploits. He killed a lion that was preying on the cattle of Amphitryon and of Thespius, king of the Boeotian town of Thespieae. During the hunt for the lion, Heracles was entertained for fifty days by Thespius and lay with one of his fifty daughters each night (or with all fifty in the same night). He also freed the Thebans from paying tribute to the Minyans of Orchomenus, leading the Theban army himself into battle. In gratitude, Creon gave him his daughter Megara as wife, and by her he had three children.



The Labors of Heracles. The first six Labors (athloi) all take place within the Peloponnese (map inset). The last six Labors take place outside of the Peloponnese throughout the Mediterranean; of these, the last three occur in the farthest western reaches of the known world.

To explore an interactive version of this map, please go to www.oup/us/morford

The Madness of Heracles

Some time later, Hera brought about a fit of madness in which Heracles killed **Megara** and her children. When he recovered his sanity, he left Thebes and went first to Thespieae, where Thespius purified him, and then to Delphi, where he sought further advice. Here the priestess of Apollo called him Heracles for the first time (until then he had been known as Alcides) and told him to go to Tiryns and there for twelve years serve Eurystheus, performing the labors that he would impose. If he did them, she said, he would become immortal.

This is the simplest story of the origin of the Labors; there is, however, great confusion over the chronology of Heracles' legends. Euripides in his *Heracles* puts the murder of Megara and her children after the Labors. Sophocles in his *Trachiniae* has Heracles marry his second wife Deianira before the Labors, whereas Apollodorus places the marriage after them. All are agreed that for a number of years Heracles served Eurystheus. Heracles' ghost says to Odysseus: "I was a son of Zeus, but infinite was my suffering; for I was slave to a far inferior mortal, and heavy were the labors he laid upon me" (Homer, *Odyssey* 11. 620–622).

The Twelve Labors

The Greek word for labors is **athloi**, which really means contests undertaken for a prize. In Heracles' case, the prize was immortality, and at least three of his Labors are really conquests of death.⁶ Heracles did not always perform the Labors unaided; sometimes Athena helped him, sometimes his nephew, **Iolaüs**. The first six Labors all take place in the northern Peloponnese, the remaining six in different parts of the world. In these last six labors, Heracles has changed from a local hero into the benefactor of all humankind. The list of the labors varies, but the twelve given are traditional and were represented on the metopes of the temple of Zeus at Olympia (see pp. 562–563).

The Peloponnesian Labors

1. The Nemean Lion Heracles was required to bring the skin of this beast to Eurystheus. Heracles killed it with a club that he had himself cut. Theocritus (in his twenty-fifth *Idyll*) makes the lion invulnerable, and Heracles has to strangle it and then flay it by using its own claws to cut its hide. The club and lionskin henceforth were Heracles' weapon and clothing and are his attributes in art and literature.

2. The Lernaean Hydra This serpent lived in the swamps of Lerna, near Argos. It had nine heads, eight of which were mortal and the ninth immortal. Each time Heracles clubbed a head off, two grew in its place. The labor was made the more difficult by a huge crab, which Hera sent to aid the Hydra. First, Heracles killed this monster, and then he killed the Hydra, helped by his nephew, Iolaüs, son of Iphicles. Each time he removed one of the heads, Iolaüs cauterized the stump with a burning brand so that another could not grow. Heracles buried the immortal head under a huge rock. He then dipped his arrows in the Hydra's poison. As for the crab, Hera took it and made it into the constellation Cancer.

3. The Cerynean Hind The hind had golden horns and was sacred to Artemis; it took its name from Mt. Cerynea in Arcadia.⁷ It was harmless, nor might it be harmed without incurring Artemis' wrath. After pursuing it for a year, Heracles caught it by the river Ladon and carried it back to Eurystheus. On the way, Artemis met him and claimed her sacred animal, but she was appeased when Heracles laid the blame on Eurystheus.

This version of the story is entirely set in the Peloponnese. A different account, however, is given by Pindar in his beautiful third *Olympian Ode*. In this version, Heracles went to the land of the Hyperboreans in the far north in search of the hind, on whose golden horns the nymph Taygete, a daughter of Atlas, had stamped the name of Artemis.⁸ Pindar's narrative allows us to connect this labor with that of the Apples of the Hesperides, for in the latter story Heracles goes to the limits of the world in search of a miraculous golden object, and again Ladon (in the form of a dragon) and Atlas appear.⁹ The labor of the Apples of the Hesperides is a conquest of death, and apparently the story of the Cerynean stag is another version of the same theme.

4. The Erymanthian Boar This destructive animal had to be brought back alive from Mt. Erymanthus. Heracles chased the boar into deep snow and there trapped it with nets. He brought it back to Eurystheus, who cowered in terror in a large jar.

This labor resulted in a side adventure (or *parergon*).¹⁰ On his way to the chase, Heracles was entertained by the centaur Pholus, who set before him a jar of wine that belonged to all the centaurs in common. When it was opened, the other centaurs, attracted by its fragrance, attacked Heracles, who repelled and pursued them. Most of them were scattered all over Greece, but Chiron was wounded by one of Heracles' poisoned arrows. Since he was immortal and could not die, he suffered incurable agonies until Prometheus interceded with Zeus and took upon himself the immortality of Chiron. Pholus also met his death when he accidentally dropped a poisoned arrow on his foot.

5. The Augean Stables Augeas, son of Helius (the Sun) and king of Elis, owned vast herds of cattle whose stables had never been cleaned out. Heracles was commanded by Eurystheus to perform the task and successfully completed it within one day by diverting the rivers Alpheus and Peneus so that they flowed through the stables. Augeas agreed to give Heracles one-tenth of his herds as a reward but then refused to keep his promise and expelled both Heracles and his own son Phyleus (who had taken Heracles' part in the quarrel). Heracles was received by a nearby prince, Dexamenus (whose name, indeed, means "the receiver"), whose daughter he saved from the centaur Eurytion. After he had finished the Labors, Heracles returned to Elis at the head of an army, took the city, and killed Augeas, making Phyleus king in his place.

It was after this expedition that Heracles was said to have instituted the Olympic Games, the greatest of Greek festivals, held every four years in honor of Zeus. He marked out the stadium by pacing it out himself, and he fetched an olive tree from the land of the Hyperboreans to be, as Pindar described it, "a shade for the sacred precinct and a crown of glory for men" (*Olympian Odes* 3. 16–18), for at that time there were no trees at Olympia, and at the games the victors were awarded a garland of olive leaves.¹¹

6. The Stymphalian Birds Heracles was required to shoot these creatures, which flocked together in a wood by the Arcadian lake Stymphalus. He flushed them out by clashing brazen castanets that Athena had given him, and then he shot them.¹²



Closer Look

Hercules and the Lernaean Hydra, by Gustave Moreau (1826–1898); oil on canvas, 1869–1876, 70 $\frac{1}{2}$ $\times$ 60 $\frac{1}{4}$ in. Moreau, who painted several of Hercules' Labors, devoted enormous effort to this painting. Hercules is young and of normal human size and anatomy. He stands in the attitude (legs reversed) of the *Apollo Belvedere* (p. 268), with his attributes of lionskin, bow (also Apollo's weapon), and club. The seven-headed Hydra towers over the hero, and in front of it lie the remains of its victims. The rocky cliffs heighten the drama, a suitable setting for the fearless hero. The conquest of the Hydra had long been a parable for the triumph of good government over disorder, but Moreau focuses on the moral stature of the hero rather than on political allegory. (*Gustave Moreau, French, 1826–1898, Hercules and the Lernaean Hydra, 1875/76, Oil on canvas, 179.3 x 154 cm, Gift of Mrs. Eugene A. Davidson, 1964.231, The Art Institute of Chicago; Photography © The Art Institute of Chicago*)

The Non-Peloponnesian Labors

7. The Cretan Bull This bull was one that Minos had refused to sacrifice to Poseidon. Heracles caught it and brought it back alive to Eurystheus. It was then turned loose and eventually came to Marathon, where in time Theseus caught and sacrificed it.

8. The Mares of Diomedes Diomedes, son of Ares, was a Thracian king who owned a herd of mares that were fed human flesh. Heracles, either alone or with an army, gained possession of them and tamed them by feeding them Diomedes himself. He took them back to Argos, where Eurystheus set them free and dedicated them to Hera. On his way to Thrace, Heracles was entertained by **Admetus**, king of Pherae, who disguised his grief at the recent death of his wife, **Alcestis**. Heracles discovered the truth and himself wrestled with Thanatos (Death), forcing Thanatos to give up Alcestis, whom he restored to her husband (see p. 266).

9. The Girdle of Hippolyta Hippolyta was queen of the Amazons, the warrior women who lived at the northern limits of the world. Heracles was sent to fetch her girdle, which had magical powers. He killed Hippolyta in battle and took the girdle. In historical times, it was displayed at Argos.

While returning from this labor, Heracles came to Troy and there rescued Hesione from the sea-monster (see p. 474). Cheated by King Laomedon of his reward, Heracles returned later (after his time as the servant of Omphale) with

Melampus and the Cattle of Phylacus

The myth of Melampus is like the tenth Labor of Heracles. He must bring back cattle from a distant place guarded, like Geryon's Erythia or Hades itself, by a dog. Like Heracles, Melampus is the bringer of cattle and even the conqueror of death itself.¹³

Bias, the son of Amythaon, was a suitor for the hand of Pero, the daughter of Neleus, for whom the bride-price was the cattle of Phylacus, the king of Phylace (in Phthia). He appealed to his brother Melampus for help, and Melampus agreed to get the cattle, even though he knew he would have to spend a year in prison at Phylace. The cattle were guarded by a monstrous dog, and Melampus was caught in the act of stealing them and so was imprisoned. After nearly a year, he heard two woodworms saying to each other that they had very nearly finished gnawing through the roofbeams of the cell. He insisted on being moved to another cell, and shortly afterward the first cell collapsed. Phylacus then set Melampus free and asked him how to cure the impotence of his son Iphiclus. Melampus agreed to tell him on condition that he be given the cattle. He sacrificed a pair of bulls, and from a vulture that was feeding on their flesh, he learned that Iphiclus' debility was the result of being frightened as a child while watching his father gelding some rams. On that occasion, Phylacus had stuck the knife, still bloody, into an oak tree, and the tree's bark by now covered it over. If it could be found and the rust from its blade scraped off and put in Iphiclus' drink for ten days, his impotence would cease. All this came to pass and Iphiclus became the father of two sons, Podarces and Protesilaüs. Melampus was given the cattle, which he drove back to Pylos and handed over to Neleus. In return, he got Pero and gave her to Bias. See also the box on p. 122.

The Temple of Zeus at Olympia and Its Sculptural Program

By the time the Olympic Games were reorganized in 776 B.C., it was commonly believed that Heracles had been their original founder in the legendary past. Construction on the Doric temple of Zeus at Olympia was begun ca. 472 and completed ca. 456 B.C. (See pp. 118–121 for a fuller discussion of the temple and its decorative program.) It is significant that this temple represents one of the first major building programs since the invasion of the Persians earlier in the century. Pausanias, the second-century A.D. travel writer, in his *Description of Greece* (5.7 ff.), describes the sanctuary and the temple, including its decoration. According to Pausanias, on the eastern and western facades, the Doric frieze included twelve metopes detailing the twelve *athloi* (labors) of Heracles that he completed in service to King Eurystheus. Pausanias describes them in the order he saw them: on the front of the temple (the eastern side), arranged from left to right: the Erymanthian Boar (7), the Mares of Diomedes (8), the Cattle of Geryon (9), the Apples of the Hesperides (10), and the Augean Stables (12); on the back (western side), apparently to be read from right to left: the Nemean Lion (1), the Lernaean Hydra (2), the Stymphalian Birds (3), the Cretan Bull (4), the Cerynean Hind (5), and the Girdle of Hippolyta (6). The omission of Cerberus (11) in Pausanias' account seems an accident; it most likely should be included among the metopes on the front, between the Apples of the Hesperides and the Augean Stables. The order of the labors does not strictly follow the arrangement of Peloponnesian and non-Peloponnesian Labors as we present it in this chapter. Some scholarly debate has arisen about the artistic logic of the ordering or whether this represents the original arrangement, but most scholars accept it.

Heracles, Assisted by Athena, Cleans the Augean Stables.

Marble metope over the east porch of the temple of Zeus at Olympia, ca. 460 B.C.; height 63 in. This local legend is given the place of honor as the final one of the series of the Labors of Heracles in the metopes of the temple of Zeus. Athena is helmeted and clothed in the Doric *peplos*, her left hand resting on her shield. With her spear (now missing) she directs Heracles as he labors to open (with a crowbar) the stables so that the river Alpheus can flush them clean. (*Alinari/Art Resource, NY*)





Athena, Heracles, and Atlas. Metope no. 10, high relief in marble, ca. 460 B.C.; height: 1.63 m. The original is in the Olympia Archaeological Museum. The artist has chosen to represent the moment that Atlas returns to Heracles, bringing the apples of the Hesperides. Heracles had taken up the burden of the vault of the sky while Atlas was away. A folded cushion helps Heracles support the weight. Athena, who customarily gives assistance to the greatest heroes, appears here in simple dress and not in her more usual battle garb. She offers gentle and unobtrusive aid with a supporting hand. It is a brilliant artistic stroke that the panel in its original placement beneath the pediment suggests Heracles is burdened by the weight of the temple roof. (*Erich Lessing/Art Resource, NY*)



W 1. Nemean Lion



W 2. Lemean Hydra



W 3. Stymphalian Birds



W 4. Cretan Bull



E 5. Kerynian Hind



E 6. Amazon



E 7. Erymanthian Boar



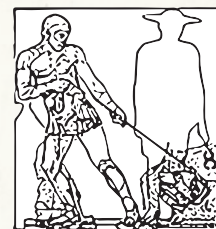
E 8. Mares of Diomedes



E 9. Geryon



E 10. Apples of the Hesperides



E 11. Cerberus



E 12. Augean Stables

Diagram of Olympia Metopes.

The diagram shows the arrangement of the metopes and the composition of the individual panels, though they are now in a fragmentary state. The depiction of Heracles performing his twelve Labors is completely appropriate for the temple of Zeus and the Olympic sanctuary: Heracles is a son of Zeus and the founder of the Olympic Games. He is seen here as the heroic competitor who eventually wins both immortality and immortal glory. If read correctly, the Nemean Lion is the first scene and the capture of Cerberus the last but one. It has been suggested that the Cleansing of the Augean Stables was placed last to give prominence to a local labor. The individual panels are composed of few figures and with a simplicity of design, and they vary in the precise, dramatic moment they choose to illustrate. According to scholars, it may be an aesthetic consideration that Athena in the present arrangement is depicted in the first, third, tenth, and twelfth panels.

an armed force and sacked the city, giving Hesione to his ally Telamon and leaving Podarces (Priam) on the throne of the ruined city.

10. The Cattle of Geryon The last three labors are most clearly conquests of death, with the abduction of Cerberus as their climax. Geryon lived on the island of Erythia, far away to the west. Geryon was a three-bodied monster, offspring of the Oceanid Callirhoë and Chrysaor; he tended a herd of cattle, helped by a giant herdsman, Eurytion, and a two-headed hound, Orthus (or Orthrus). Heracles' labor was to bring the cattle back to Eurystheus. To reach Erythia, Heracles was helped by Helios (the Sun), who gave him a golden cup in which to sail upon the River of Ocean, which girdles the world. He killed Orthus, Eurytion, and Geryon, and then sailed back in the cup to Tartessus (i.e., Spain) with the cattle. He returned the cup to Helios and then began to drive the cattle back to Greece.

As a monument of his journey to the western edge of the world, he set up the Pillars of Heracles at the Atlantic entrance to the Mediterranean. They are sometimes identified with the rocks of Calpe (Gibraltar) and Abyla (Ceuta), which flank the Straits of Gibraltar. In the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries these Pillars became a significant part of the political imagery of the Spanish monarchy, symbolizing the crossing of the Atlantic Ocean by Spanish explorers and traders, who returned with the wealth of the Americas to the greater glory of the monarchy. Thus, as early as 1526, Charles V had adopted the Pillars as his symbol, with the motto *Plus Ultra* ("further beyond"), and on his triumphal entry into Seville that year he was greeted as "The new Hercules, who has established the limits of the new world, just as Hercules established those of the ancient world." The imagery of the Pillars continued well into the seventeenth century, when, for example, they were prominent in the Arch of the Mint designed by Peter Paul Rubens for the Joyful Entry of the Spanish Archduke Ferdinand into Antwerp in 1535.¹⁴

Heracles' journey back to Greece has many *parerga*. While crossing the south of France, he was attacked by the tribe of the Ligurians and exhausted his supply of arrows defending himself. He prayed for help from Zeus, who sent a rain of stones that gave Heracles the ammunition he needed to drive off the attackers. He then crossed the Alps and traversed Italy, where he was said to have founded several cities.¹⁵ While Heracles was in Italy, the Italian fire god **Cacus** stole the cattle of Geryon. He killed the thief and recovered the cattle. (See pp. 674–675 for Vergil's version of this story, which he locates in Rome.)

Heracles' wanderings in Italy also took him across the strait to Sicily. There he wrestled with Eryx (king of the mountain of the same name at the western end of the island), whom he killed. He returned to Greece by traveling around the head of the Adriatic and through Dalmatia. At the Isthmus of Corinth, he killed the giant and brigand, Alcioneus. As for the cattle, Eurystheus sacrificed them to Hera.

Herodotus tells quite a different version of the legend of Geryon. In this narrative, Heracles journeyed to the cold lands beyond the Danube, and there lay with Echidna (Snake Woman), a monster who was half woman and half serpent, who bore him three sons, Agathyrsus, Gelonus, and Scythes. When the three grew up, only Scythes was able to draw a bow and put on a belt that Heracles had left behind. The other two were driven away by Echidna, and Scythes became king and ancestor of the Scythians.¹⁶

11. The Apples of the Hesperides The Hesperides were the three daughters of Night, living far away to the west; they guarded a tree on which grew golden apples. The Hesperides were helped by the serpent **Ladon**, who was coiled around the tree. The apples had originally been a wedding gift from Ge to Hera when she married Zeus, and Ge put them in the garden of the Hesperides. Heracles first had to find the sea-god Nereus and learn from him the whereabouts of the garden. Nereus would tell him only after he had turned himself into many different shapes, being held all the while by Heracles. At the garden, in Euripides' version, Heracles killed Ladon and plucked the apples himself. In the tradition represented by the metopes at Olympia, however, he had the help of the Titan **Atlas**, who held up the heavens. Heracles, helped by Athena, took the heavens on his own shoulders while Atlas fetched the apples. He then returned the load to Atlas' shoulders and brought the apples back to Eurystheus. Athena is then said to have taken the apples back to the garden of the Hesperides.

This labor is a conquest of death. The apples are symbols of immortality, and the tree in the garden of the Hesperides is a kind of Tree of Life. As in the labor of Geryon, the journey to a mysterious place in the far west is really a journey to the realm of death.

On his journey to the garden of the Hesperides, Heracles killed the king of Egypt, Busiris, who would sacrifice all strangers to Zeus.¹⁷ In Libya he conquered the giant **Antaeus**, son of Ge and Poseidon, who would wrestle with those who came to his kingdom. Antaeus was invincible: every time an opponent threw him, he came in contact with his mother (Earth) and rose with renewed strength. Thus Antaeus had killed all comers and used their skulls in building a temple to his father, Poseidon. Heracles held him aloft and crushed him to death.

Some versions of this story take Heracles to the Caucasus Mountains. There he found Prometheus chained to his rock and released him after killing the eagle that tormented him (see p. 99). Prometheus advised him to use Atlas in getting the apples and foretold the battle against the Ligurians. On this occasion, too, Prometheus took over the immortality of Chiron and satisfied Zeus by letting Chiron die in his place.

12. Cerberus The final labor was to fetch Cerberus, the three-headed hound of Hades. This labor is most clearly a conquest of death, and Heracles himself (in the *Odyssey* ll. 617–626) said that it was the most difficult of the



Heracles Shows Cerberus to Eurystheus. Etruscan hydria from Caere, ca. 530 B.C.; height 17 in. The terrified Eurystheus leaps into a storage jar to escape from the Hound of Hades, which bares its three sets of teeth while its snakes furiously hiss at him. Heracles, with club and lionskin, strides forward confidently, guiding Cerberus with a leash. The humor in this splendid vase is remarkable. Compare Blake's *Cerberus* on page 370. (*Réunion des Musées Nationaux/Art Resource, NY*)

Labors and that he could not have achieved it without the aid of Hermes and Athena. In the Underworld, Heracles wrestled with Cerberus, brought him back to Eurystheus, and then returned him to Hades.

In Hades, Heracles saw Theseus and Pirithoüs, chained fast because of their attempt to carry off Persephone. He was able to release Theseus, who out of gratitude sheltered him after his madness and the murder of Megara. He also saw the ghost of Meleager, whose sister, if he still had one living, he offered to marry. Meleager named Deïanira, “upon whose neck was still the green of youth, nor did she know yet of the ways of Aphrodite, charmer of men” (Bacchylides, *Epini-cian Ode* 5. 172–175). Thus the train of events that eventually led to the death of Heracles was set in motion.

In conclusion, we translate a chorus from Euripides’ *Heracles*, which tells of the great hero’s Labors. This choral ode also reveals the nature of our sources for Greek legends, where the dry facts are enlivened by poetic expression (Euripides, *Heracles* 352–427):



Audio

I wish to offer a glorious crown for labors done, by singing the praises of him who descended into the darkness of earth’s realm of shades—whether I am to call him the son of Zeus or of Amphitryon. For the renown of noble deeds is a joy to those who have died. First, he cleared Zeus’ grove of the lion; and he wore its tawny skin upon his back, with the fearful jaws of the beast framing his fair head. (352–363)

He laid low the mountain race of savage Centaurs with his deadly arrows, slaughtering them with his winged shafts. The beautiful stream of Peneus was a witness and the vast extent of the plains without crops and the vales of Mt. Pelion and the places on the green glens of Homole—all haunts where they filled their hands with weapons of pine and, galloping as horses, brought fear to the land of the Thessalians. (364–374) 10

He slew the dappled hind with golden horns and dedicated this ravaging plunderer to the huntress Artemis of Oenoë.

He mounted the chariot of Diomedes and mastered with the bit the four mares, who ranged wild in stables drenched in blood and reveled in their horrid feasts of human flesh with ravenous jaws. (380–385)

In his labors for the king of Mycenae, he crossed over the banks of the silver-flowing Hebrus; and along the sea-cliff of Pelion, by the waters of the Amaurus, he killed with his bow Cynus, the guest-murderer who lived alone near Amphanaea. (386–393) 20

He came to the western home of the singing maidens, to pluck from amid the golden leaves the fruit of the apple, and the fiery dragon who kept guard coiled around the tree, hard even to approach, him he killed.

He made his way into the farthest corners of the sea and made them safe for men who ply the oar. (400–402)

Having come to the abode of Atlas, he extended his hand to support the vault of heaven in its midst, and by his manly strength held up the starry homes of the gods.

He crossed the swell of the Euxine Sea to the land of the Amazons, who rode in force where many rivers flow into Lake Maeotis. Mustering a band of friends from Hellas, he sought to win the gold-encrusted adornment of the warrior maid—the deadly booty of her girdle—and Hellas captured 30

the renowned prize of the foreign queen, which is kept safe in Mycenae. (408–418)

He seared the many heads of the deadly monster, the Lernaean Hydra, and dipped his arrows in its venom; with that he killed three-bodied Geryon, the herdsman of Erythia.

He won the glorious crown for these and other labors; and he sailed to the tearful realm of Hades—the final task of all. (425–427)

Other Deeds of Heracles

Cycnus, Syleus, and the Cercopes

Heracles fought and killed a number of harmful beings. Cycnus, son of Ares, used to rob men passing on their way through Thessaly to Delphi. Heracles, helped by Athena and with Iolaüs as charioteer, killed Cycnus and wounded Ares.¹⁸ Another robber was Syleus, who lived by the Straits of Euboea. Heracles destroyed his vineyard, in which Syleus compelled passers-by to work, and then killed Syleus himself.

More folktale than myth is Heracles' encounter with the Cercopes, whose home is placed in various parts of Greece or Asia Minor. They were a pair of dwarfs who spent their time playing tricks on people. They had been warned by their mother "to beware of the black-bottomed man." Now as Heracles was asleep under a tree, they attempted to steal his weapons, but he caught them and slung them from a pole across his shoulders upside down. They thus had an uninterrupted view of his backside which, since the lionskin did not cover it, had been burned black by the sun. They joked about the sight so much that Heracles, himself amused, let them go. Later they tried to trick Zeus and were punished by being turned into either apes or stones.

Hylas

Heracles was among the heroes who sailed on the *Argo*. But he was too important to be subordinate to other heroes in the saga, and so he soon dropped out of the expedition. In one version, he went looking for the boy Hylas, whom he loved. When the *Argo* put in at Cios (in Asia Minor), Hylas went to a nearby spring to draw water, and the water-nymphs were so entranced by his beauty that they pulled him into the water, to remain with them forever. Heracles spent so long searching for him that the rest of the Argonauts sailed away without him, and he returned on his own to Argos after establishing a cult of Hylas at Cios. In late antiquity, the people still searched for him annually, calling out his name.¹⁹

Military Expeditions

Heracles took part in Zeus' battle against the giants, during which he slew the terrible Alcyoneus. He attacked Laomedon, king of Troy, and Augeas, king of Elis, who had both cheated him. He made an expedition against Neleus, king of Pylos, who had refused to purify Heracles after the murder of Iphitus. He killed eleven of the twelve sons of Neleus; the twelfth, Nestor, eventually became king



Hylas and the Nymphs, by J. W. Waterhouse (1849–1917); oil on canvas, 1896, 38 × 63 in. The young Hylas is lured to his fate by seven water-nymphs. The artist brilliantly combines English Victorian ideals of female beauty and landscape (the latter in colors of great beauty) with psychological insight that anticipates Freud. (City Art Gallery, Manchester, England)



Closer Look

of Pylos and took part in the Trojan War. According to Hesiod, one of the sons of Neleus was Periclymenus, to whom Poseidon had given the ability to transform himself into every sort of bird, beast, or insect. With the help of Athena, Heracles recognized him in the form of a bee settled upon the yoke of his horse-drawn chariot and shot him with an arrow.

In this expedition also, says Homer, Heracles wounded the god Hades, “in Pylos among the corpses” (*Iliad* 5. 395–397), as if the expedition were another conquest of death. Homer also mentions that Heracles wounded Hera, and says that this was another example of Heracles’ violence—“brutal and violent man, who did not scruple to do evil and wounded the Olympian gods with his arrows” (*Iliad* 5. 403–404). This is an older view of Heracles and more likely represents the character of the original mythical hero than that of Pindar, who makes the following protest (*Olympian Odes* 9. 29–36):

How would Heracles have brandished his club with his hands against the trident, when, in defense of Pylos Poseidon pushed him back, and Apollo shook him and drove him back with his silver bow, nor did Hades keep his staff unmoved, with which he drives mortal bodies to the hollow ways of the dead? Hurl this story, my mouth, far away!

We can see that by Pindar’s time (the first half of the fifth century B.C.) the transformation of Heracles was already well advanced, from the primitive strongman into a paragon of virtue. Heracles also made an expedition

against Hippocoön, king of Sparta, and his sons, who had given assistance to Neleus. Iphicles was killed in this campaign. While returning home from Sparta, Heracles lay at Tegea with Auge, whose father, fearing an oracle that Auge's son would kill her brothers, had made her priestess of Athena. The son she conceived was Telephus, and mother and baby crossed the sea to Asia Minor floating in a chest. There Telephus eventually became king of the Mysians.²⁰

In Thessaly, Heracles appeared as an ally of Aegimius, king of the Dorians, against the attacks of his neighbors, the Lapiths and the Dryopes. This legend brings Heracles back to central Greece, where the legends of the last part of his life are placed.

Heracles, Deïanira, and Iole

Marriage to Deïanira

Some time after the completion of the Labors, Heracles fulfilled the promise he had made to the soul of Meleager to marry his sister Deïanira, daughter of Oeneus, king of Calydon. To win her, Heracles had to wrestle with the river-god **Acheloüs**, who was horned like a bull and had the power to change himself into different shapes. This is how Sophocles describes the scene (*Trachiniae* 513–525):

They came together desiring marriage; alone between them as umpire was Aphrodite, maker of marriages. Then was there confusion of sounds, the beating of fists, the twang of bow, the clash of bull's horns. There were the wrestling holds, the painful collision of heads, and the groans of both. But she, the prize, fair and delicate, sat afar upon a hill, waiting for him who was to be her husband.

In the struggle, Heracles broke off one of Acheloüs' horns; after his victory, he gave it back, receiving in return the miraculous horn of Amalthea, which could supply its owner with as much food and drink as he wished.²¹ Heracles returned with Deïanira to Tiryns. On the way, the centaur **Nessus** carried Deïanira across the river Evenus. When he attempted to violate her, Heracles shot him with his bow. As Nessus was dying, he advised Deïanira to gather some of the blood that flowed from his wound, which had been caused by an arrow that had been dipped in the Hydra's poison. It would, he said, prevent Heracles from loving any other woman more than he loved Deïanira. She therefore kept the blood, and for a number of years she and Heracles lived at Tiryns, where she bore him children, including a son, Hyllus, and a daughter, Macaria.

Iole

But Heracles fell in love with Iole, daughter of Eurytus, king of Oechalia, who had once taught Heracles archery. Eurytus refused to let him have Iole, even though he won an archery contest that was to decide whose wife Iole should be. Heracles returned to Tiryns, bitter at the insult, and when Iphitus, brother of Iole, came to Tiryns in search of some lost mares, Heracles threw him from the citadel

to his death. For this murder, he had to leave Tiryns, going first to Pylos, where Neleus refused to purify him. Having obtained purification at Amyclae, he went to Delphi to find out what more he should do to be cured of the madness that had caused him to kill Iphitus. When the Pythia would not reply, he attempted to carry off the sacred tripod, intending to establish an oracle of his own (see illustration on p. 572). Apollo himself wrestled with him to prevent this theft, and their fight ended when Zeus threw a thunderbolt between them. Finally, Heracles obtained the advice he had asked for, which was that he must be sold as a slave and serve for one year.

Omphale

Accordingly, Hermes auctioned Heracles, and he was bought by Omphale, queen of the Lydians; he served her for a year and performed various tasks for her in keeping with his heroic character. Later versions, however, make Heracles perform women's work for the queen and picture him dressed as a woman and spinning wool. At the end of his year, he mounted the expedition against Troy and then returned to Greece, determined to punish Eurytus and to win Iole.

The Death of Heracles

Deïanira, meanwhile, was living in Trachis, where King Ceyx had received her and Heracles after they left the Peloponnese. According to Sophocles, whose *Trachiniae* is the most important source for the last part of Heracles' life, she knew nothing of Oechalia and Iole until the herald Lichas brought news of the sack of the city. She had not seen Heracles for fifteen months, before his servitude to Omphale. In this account, Heracles killed Eurytus and sacked Oechalia on his way back from Asia, sending Iole and the other captive women back to Trachis with Lichas. When she realized that Heracles loved Iole, Deïanira, hoping to win him back, dipped a robe in the blood of Nessus and sent it to Heracles by Lichas' hand for him to wear at his thanksgiving sacrifice to Zeus.

As the flames of the sacrificial fire warmed the poisoned blood, the robe clung to Heracles and burned him with unendurable torment. In his agony, he hurled Lichas to his death in the sea and had himself carried back to Trachis, where a huge funeral pyre was made for him upon Mt. Oeta. Deïanira killed herself with a sword when she realized what she had done, while Hyllus went with his father to Oeta. There Heracles instructed Hyllus to marry Iole after his death and gave his bow to the shepherd Poeas (father of Philoctetes), since he alone had dared to light the pyre. So the mortal part of Heracles was burned away and he gained immortality, ascending to Olympus, there to be reconciled with Hera and to marry her daughter Hebe. This is Pindar's version (*Isthmian Odes* 4. 61–67):

To Olympus went Alcmena's son, when he had explored every land and the cliff-girt levels of the foaming sea, to tame the straits for seafarers. Now beside Zeus he enjoys a perfect happiness; he is loved and honored by the immortals; Hebe is his wife, and he is lord of a golden palace, the husband of Hera's daughter.



Nessus and Deianira, by Guido Reni (1575–1642); oil on canvas, 1623, 104 × 77 in. Reni painted a series of four scenes from the life and death of Heracles for Ferdinando Gonzaga, Duke of Mantua, in 1621. When the original *Nessus and Deianeira* was removed to Prague (where it still is) during the sack of Mantua by the troops of Charles V, Reni replaced it with this splendid and romantic interpretation of the myth. The young centaur, triumphant in his conquest, bears off Deianira, who twists away as she realizes the fate that has overtaken her, while Heracles in the background takes an arrow from his quiver. Thus Reni focuses on the joy of the centaur, soon to be turned to tragedy for himself, Deianira, and Heracles. The contrast with the stark realism of the Attic artist's painting on the seventh-century B.C. vase on p. 573 is a remarkable example of the way in which the same myth can inspire different emotions. (*Erich Lessing/Art Resource, NY*)



Heracles and Apollo Struggle for the Pythian Tripod. Attic red-figure amphora by the Andocides painter, ca. 520 B.C.; height of vase 22 ½ in. Athena is armed with helmet, spear, and shield, and her aegis is tasseled with snakes, with a Gorgon's head at the center. She stands at the left watching Heracles and Apollo struggling for the Pythian tripod. (Bildarchiv Preussischer Kulturbesitz/Art Resource, NY)

Sophocles' *Trachiniae* ends with Heracles, in torment, being carried from his palace to the pyre on Mt. Oeta. In this scene, Hyllus says: "No one foresees what is to come" (1270), thus leaving the destiny of Heracles shrouded in ambiguity. Ovid's description is explicit (*Metamorphoses* 9. 239–272):

And now . . . the flames were attacking the limbs that did not fear them and him who despised them. The gods were anxious for earth's champion [Hercules] and them did Jupiter . . . in happiness thus address: "Your fear is my joy, O gods . . . let not your hearts tremble with empty fear, despite Oeta's flames! He who conquered all will conquer the flames which you see, and only his mother's part will feel the power of Vulcan [i.e., fire]. That part which he inherited from me is immortal, immune to death, impervious to fire, and it will I receive in the heavens when its time on earth is done. . . ." 10
The gods approved. Meanwhile, Vulcan had consumed all that fire could consume, and the recognizable form of Hercules was no longer to be seen. He kept no part of himself that came from his mother, and he kept only the features drawn from Jupiter. . . . So, when the hero of Tiryns had put off his mortal body, his better part kept its vigor. He began to seem greater in size and awe-inspiring with august dignity. The almighty Father received him as he ascended into the surrounding clouds in a four-horse chariot, and placed him among the shining constellations. 20

Heracles: Man, Hero, and God

Odysseus describes his meeting with the ghost of Heracles in this way (Homer, *Odyssey* 11. 601–603):

Then saw I mighty Heracles—his ghost, but he himself delights in feasting among the immortal gods, with fair-ankled Hebe for his wife.

In this very early passage, the ambiguity of Heracles' status as man and god is evident. That he was a man before he became a god is shown by his name (which means "glory of Hera"), since Greek gods do not form their names from compounds of other gods' names. Certainly Euripides, in his tragedies *Alcestis* and *Heracles*, portrays him more as a mortal than a god, as can be seen, for example, in the scene from the *Heracles* in which Lyssa, the goddess of madness, is sent by Hera to torment Heracles.

Since his legend is particularly associated with Argos, Mycenae, and Tiryns, Heracles' saga may have had its origin in a prince of Tiryns who was vassal to the lord of Mycenae. This fits with the theme of subservience to Eurystheus. But other areas with which Heracles is especially associated are Boeotia (the traditional setting of his birth and of a group of his exploits) and Trachis, the scene of his final exploits and death.



The Death of Nessus. Detail of an Attic black-figure amphora, ca. 620 B.C.; height of vase 48 in., of painting 14 in. The scene is painted on the neck of the vase, with owls, a swan, and a pigeon on the handles. The names of Heracles (written right to left) and Nessus (spelled "Netos") are given. Heracles finishes Nessus off with a sword, grasping his hair and violently thrusting his left foot into the Centaur's back. He ignores Nessus' pleas for mercy, shown by the gesture of touching the chin. The hero does not wear the lionskin, nor does he carry his club and bow. (*Nimatallah/Art Resource, NY*)

This leads to one of two possibilities: either legends of the hero of Tiryns spread to Boeotia and other parts of Greece, where his fame attracted local legends, or else he was brought into Greece by early settlers from the north and his fame spread all over Greece. The latter explanation seems the more acceptable, but it has led many people to believe wrongly that Heracles was a Dorian hero, brought in by invaders who entered Greece at the end of the Mycenaean Age. It is better to suppose that Heracles is an older hero common to all the Greek peoples but associated more with certain areas (Argos, Thebes, Trachis) than with others. Thus we find his exploits covering the whole of the Greek world and his legends and cult flourishing in areas of Greek colonization, such as Asia Minor and Italy (where as Hercules he passed into the Roman state religion).

Many people have thought of Heracles primarily as a god. Herodotus believed that Heracles the god was quite distinct from Heracles the man and that the god was one of the twelve ancient gods of Egypt. He himself even traveled to the Phoenician city of Tyre, whose chief god, Melkart, was identified with Heracles, to find support for his theory. Since the mythology of Melkart is virtually unknown, the similarities between him and Heracles remain unclear; nor can we establish the exact relationship between Heracles and other Oriental figures with whom he shares many similarities, for example, the Israelite hero Samson, the Mesopotamian Gilgamesh, and the Cilician god Sandas. These figures may have contributed elements to the Greek hero's legend. In general, it is safe to reject Herodotus' theory and accept the nearly unanimous view of the ancients that Heracles the man became a god.

Still, the origins of Heracles are a subject of great interest. The similarities to the Eastern figures mentioned are undeniable, as are similarities to

The Apotheosis of Hercules, by Peter Paul Rubens (1577–1640); oil on panel, 1636, 11 × 12 ¾ in. In this oil sketch for Philip IV's hunting lodge near Madrid, Rubens represents Ovid's narrative at the moment when Hercules ascends from the pyre to Olympus. The flames can be seen at the bottom left, and the bulky hero (Ovid says that "he began to seem greater in size") climbs on the chariot provided by Jupiter. A flying putto puts the victor's wreath on his head, and a second guides the chariot. Rubens does not show Jupiter, so as not to detract from the focus on the triumphant hero. (Musée Royaux des Beaux-Arts de Belgique, Brussels, Belgium)



the Indian hero Indra, who killed the three-headed monster Visvarupa and released the cattle penned in his cave. The monsters that Heracles overcame, such as the lion and the many-headed Hydra, belong more to Eastern mythology, yet Heracles is very definitely a Greek hero, and his myths are Greek traditional tales. Many different tales, then, have become attached to the hero called Heracles. The process can be seen in the large number of *parerga* that cluster around several of the Labors. Some of the myths have a structure consistent with Propp's Quest (see pp. 13–14), and in these the basic structure of the myth remains, despite its varied appearances. The primitive origins of much of Heracles' mythology are apparent from his violence and brutality. His association with many different types of animals has led some scholars to see in him a kind of "Master of Animals," not least because of his association with cattle, the chief source of food in a pastoral society. There is much that is persuasive in Walter Burkert's conclusion:

*Heracles is, basically, not a heroic figure in the Homeric sense: he is not a warrior fighting warriors, he is mainly concerned with animals, just as he is a savage clad in a skin; and his main job is to tame and bring back the animals which are eaten by man.*²²

The Greek hero, son of Zeus and exemplar of strength and patience, is also the man wielding the primitive weapon of the club and wearing the lionskin,



The Choice of Heracles, by Annibale Carracci (1560–1609); oil on canvas, 1596, 65 $\frac{3}{4}$ × 93 $\frac{1}{4}$ in. Formerly the central painting in the ceiling of the *camerino* (private office) of the Farnese Palace, Carracci's painting is a lucid interpretation of Prodicus' parable. Heracles, identified by his club and lionskin, ponders the choice of Pleasure (to the viewer's right), whose attributes include an actor's mask and a musical instrument. On the other side, Virtue, holding a sheathed sword, points to the rocky upward path, at the top of which stands Pegasus. At the bottom left a poet sits ready to record the deeds of the hero, whose eyes indicate that he has already made his choice of Virtue. In the central background is a palm tree, source of the future victor's wreath. (*Galleria di Capodimonte, Naples, Italy*)

whose origins lie perhaps far from Greece and certainly in a time long before the development even of Mycenaean culture.

So diverse a character attracted a variety of interpretations and uses. Indeed, as Aristotle pointed out in the *Poetics* (8), his very diversity made it impossible for a unified epic or tragedy to be written about him. Only three extant Greek tragedies deal with his legend—Sophocles' *Trachiniae* and Euripides' *Heracles* and *Alcestitis*. To the comic poets like Aristophanes, he is good material for slapstick; in the *Frogs*, for example, he is largely motivated by gluttony and lust. Several Greek vases portray him as drinking (and losing) in contests with Dionysus, and in the *Alcestitis* he is entertained by Admetus and given plenty to drink before he learns the truth about Alcestitis.²³

More significant was the use made of his virtues by the moralists and philosophers, to whom Heracles became a model of unselfish fortitude, laboring for the good of humankind and achieving immortality by his virtue. This process is best typified by the famous parable told by Prodicus of Ceos:²⁴ As a young man, Heracles was faced with the choice between two women, representing Pleasure (with ease) and Virtue (with hardship), and chose the latter. Heracles was especially important as a paradigm of virtue in Roman Stoicism, whose doctrines set high value on the Heraclean qualities of endurance and

self-reliance. In a modern setting, the character of Harcourt-Reilly in T. S. Eliot's *The Cocktail Party* (1949) combines the Heracles of the myth of Alcestis with the virtues of a Christlike hero.

Perhaps we would do better to leave Heracles by returning to the ancient invocation to him in the *Homeric Hymn to Heracles, the Lion-Hearted* (15). Here we may focus on the man who after a lifetime of toil became a hero and a god:

Of Heracles will I sing, son of Zeus, whom Alcmena bore in Thebes, city of delightful dances, when she had lain with the son of Cronus, lord of the dark clouds, to be by far the greatest of men on earth. He traversed long ago vast distances of land and sea at the order of King Eurystheus; many were the bold deeds he did, many were the things he endured. Now he dwells in joy in the beautiful palace of snowy Olympus and has for wife slender-ankled Hebe.

Hail, lord, son of Zeus. Grant [me] both excellence and wealth.²⁵

The Heraclidae

Alcmena, Eurystheus, and the Children of Heracles

After the death of Heracles, his mother Alcmena and his children were persecuted by Eurystheus. King Ceyx was unable to protect them, and so they fled to Athens. The Athenians fought Eurystheus, who died in battle with his five sons. His head was brought to Alcmena, who gouged out the eyes with brooches.

According to Euripides, however, in his drama *Heraclidae*, Alcmena and her grandchildren were received at Athens by King Demophon, son of Theseus. Demophon was ordered "by all the oracles to sacrifice a virgin, daughter of a noble father, to the daughter of Demeter [Persephone], to be the defeat of our enemies and the salvation of the city" (*Heraclidae* 407–409, 402). Macaria, daughter of Heracles, voluntarily offered herself for the sacrifice and so brought victory to the Athenians. In the battle, Iolaüs, the nephew of Heracles, was miraculously rejuvenated by Heracles and Hebe and pursued Eurystheus, whom he captured and brought back to Alcmena. The play ends with Alcmena gloating over her prisoner and ordering him off to be executed. With his last words Eurystheus prophesies that his body, if it were buried in Attica, would protect the land from invaders.

Yet another version was given by Pindar (*Pythian Odes* 9. 79–83):

Seven-gated Thebes knew that the Right Time (*Kairos*) favored Iolaüs. Him they buried, after he had cut off the head of Eurystheus with his sword, deep in the earth in the tomb of Amphitryon the charioteer. His grandfather [Amphitryon] lay there, guest of the Spartoi, who lived as a foreigner in Cadmeia, city of white horses.

In this version, Iolaüs killed Eurystheus, and his body, rather than that of Eurystheus, protected the foreign land that had welcomed him—in this case, Thebes (which was Pindar's own city).

Alcmena herself also became associated with a cult. In one version, she died in Thebes and was transported by Hermes to the Elysian Fields, where she

married Rhadamanthys, brother of Minos. In the version of Apollodorus, she married Rhadamanthys in Thebes after the death of Amphitryon, but was reunited with Amphitryon in the Underworld. As she was being carried out to burial in a coffin Hermes, at the command of Zeus, substituted for her body a large stone, which the sons of Heracles discovered (for the coffin had suddenly become very heavy) and set up in a shrine sacred to her.²⁶

The Return of the Heraclidae

The saga of the descendants of Heracles (the Heraclidae) explains the occupation of a large part of the Peloponnese by Dorian tribes in the period after the end of the Mycenaean Age. Hyllus married Iole as his father had commanded and consulted Delphi about his return to the Peloponnese. He was advised to wait “until the third fruit” and was told that victory would come “from the Narrows.” After waiting two more years, Hyllus attacked by way of the Isthmus of Corinth. He himself was killed in single combat by Echemus, king of Tegea; his army withdrew, and a truce of one hundred years was agreed upon. At the end of that time, the Heraclid Temenus again consulted the oracle, who told him that the “third fruit” meant not the third harvest but the third generation, and that “the Narrows” meant the entrance to the Gulf of Corinth. Temenus therefore invaded the northwest Peloponnese, crossing over near Patrae and taking as a guide a “three-eyed man” in accordance with the advice of the oracle; this was an Aetolian exile named Oxylus, whom Temenus found riding a one-eyed horse. With his help, the Heraclids defeated the Peloponnesian defenders, who were led by Tisamenus, son of Orestes. Thucydides (1. 12) relates these events to the disruptions in Greece that followed the Trojan War and the return of the Greek leaders. He says that “the Dorians with the Heraclidae took possession of the Peloponnese in the eightieth year [after the fall of Troy].”

Thus the “Return of the Heraclidae” took place. The leaders divided up the three principal areas that they had conquered. Lacedaemon (Sparta) was given to Procles and Eurysthenes, sons of the lately dead leader Aristodemus, and they became founders of the two royal houses of Sparta. Argos fell to Temenus, and Messene to Cresphontes. Temenus was killed by his sons, whom he had passed over in the succession to his throne. Cresphontes was also murdered, along with two of his sons, by a rival Heraclid, Polyphontes. His widow, Merope, was forced to become Polyphontes’ queen, but she succeeded in getting her surviving son Aepytus out of the kingdom to Aetolia, where he grew up. Later, Aepytus secretly returned to Messene and was recognized by Merope, with whose connivance he killed Polyphontes and recovered his father’s throne. Of the three Dorian kingdoms, Sparta and Argos flourished for many centuries, but Messene was subjugated by the Spartans within a comparatively short time.



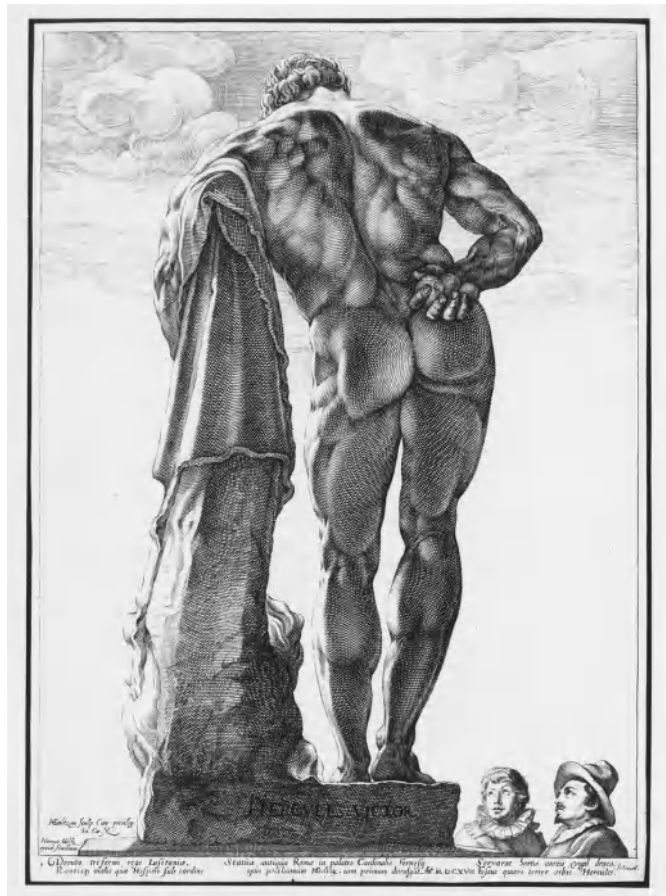
The Farnese Hercules. Marble copy by Glycon, early third century A.D., of an original by Lysippus, mid-fourth century B.C.; height 125 in. This huge statue was found in the Baths of Caracalla at Rome, for which it had been specially copied. The weary hero leans on his club, which rests on a stump over which the lionskin is draped. His vast body is bursting with mountainous muscles. It has been suggested (by M. Robertson) that he is “an athlete in decay”; more likely, his stance is one of weariness after his labors. (Alinari/Art Resource, NY)

Some Later Survivals of the Myth of Heracles

Besides the Pillars of Heracles mentioned here in connection with the tenth Labor, there were many other examples, ancient and more modern, of the desire of political leaders to identify themselves with Heracles. Thus, for example, the Roman emperor Augustus was identified with Heracles on his return from campaigning in Spain in 24 B.C. by the poet Horace (*Odes* 3.14). Horace was thinking of Heracles as the hero who made the world a better place by ridding it of monsters and other threats to civilization. More trivial—indeed ridiculous—was the emperor Nero (d. 68 A.D.), who, it was said at the time of his death, was preparing to fight, in the guise of Heracles, a specially prepared Nemean lion in the amphitheater. More than a century later, the emperor Commodus (d. A.D. 192) gave himself the title of *Hercules Romanus* and was portrayed clothed in Heracles' lionskin and holding the apples of the Hesperides (see p. 642).

In Europe, the image of the “Gallic” Heracles was well known in the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries. This Heracles had his origin in the *Herakles* of Lucian, a Greek author of the second century A.D. According to Lucian, this “Celtic” Heracles was an old man, with the traditional emblems of the lionskin,

Hercules Victor (The Farnese Hercules), by Hendrik Goltzius (1558–1617). Engraving 1589; published 1617. Goltzius's engraving shows the overmuscular body of the hero from the rear, clutching the Apples of the Hesperides in his right hand. The two contemporary observers emphasize the vastness of his body silhouetted against the sky. The Latin iambic lines (to the left and right of the caption) say: “I, Hercules, terror of the world, rest, weary after subduing the three-formed king [Geryon] of further Spain and after taking the apples from the turning-point of Hesperus, where the never-sleeping serpent had guarded them in gardens of gold.” (*V&A Images, London/Art Resource, NY*)



the club, and the bow, but was also an orator who drew people to himself by the power of his rhetoric. Renaissance handbooks show him as an old man from whose tongue chains extend to his audience, who follow him willingly, overcome by his rhetoric. The Gallic Heracles was used especially in French political imagery: For example, King Henri IV was welcomed into Avignon in 1600 as “L’Hercule Gaulois,” and seven arches decorating the processional route celebrated his Labors.

Select Bibliography

Brommer, Frank. *Heracles: The Twelve Labors of the Hero in Ancient Art and Literature.*

Translated by Shirley Schwartz. New Rochelle, NY: Caratzas, 1986.

Galinsky, G. Karl. *The Herakles Theme: The Adaptation of the Hero in Literature from Homer to the Twentieth Century.* Oxford: Blackwell, 1972.

For further material see notes 25 and 26 below.

Primary Sources

Sources in the Chapter

Euripides	<i>Heracles</i> 352–427
Homer	<i>Iliad</i> 19.103–105
	<i>Odyssey</i> 11.601–603, 620–633
Homeric Hymn 15	<i>To Heracles, the Lion-Hearted</i>
Ovid	<i>Metamorphoses</i> 9.239–272
Pindar	<i>Isthmian Ode</i> 4.61–67
	<i>Nemean Ode</i> 1.33–72
	<i>Pythian Ode</i> 9.79–83
Sophocles	<i>Trachiniae (Women of Trachis)</i> 513–525

Additional Sources

Apollodorus	<i>Library</i> 2.4.5–2.8.5
Apollonius of Rhodes	<i>Argonautica</i> 1.1153–1357
Euripides	<i>Heracidae</i> (Children of Heracles)
Herodotus	2.43.1–2.45.3 (the Egyptian Heracles)
Plautus	<i>Amphitryon</i>
Seneca	<i>Hercules Furens (The Madness of Hercules)</i>
	<i>Hercules Oetaeus (Hercules on Mt. Oeta)</i>
Xenophon	<i>Memorabilia</i> 2.1.21–2.1.34 (Heracles at the crossroads)

Notes

1. The Greek form of his name, which means “glory of Hera,” is used here. Its Latin form is Hercules. He is also called Alcides (i.e., descendant of Alcaeus) and sometimes Amphitryoniades (i.e., son of Amphitryon).
2. Licymnius, surviving son of Electryon, was later killed by a son of Heracles.
3. According to Apollodorus, Amphitryon was helped by Creon after ridding Thebes of a monstrous fox with the aid of Cephalus and his magic hound (see pp. 585–587).
4. Eileithyia sat outside Alcmena’s door with her hands clasped around her knees in a gesture of sympathetic magic. Alcmena’s servant Galanthis broke the spell by

rushing out crying, "My mistress has borne a son!" Eileithyia leaped up and unclasped her hands, and the birth took place. She punished Galanthis by turning her into a weasel.

5. Eurystus was grandson of Apollo and king of the Euboean city of Oechalia. See p. 570 for his death at the hands of Heracles.
6. The Cattle of Geryon, the Apples of the Hesperides, and Cerberus.
7. Although the hind is female, it is always shown with horns. Euripides makes the hind destructive, and some authors call it the Cerynitian hind, from the Achaeian river Cerynites.
8. Atlas was the name of a mountain in Arcadia as well as of the more famous range in North Africa.
9. The hind is shown beside the tree of the Hesperides in a vase painting.
10. *Parerga* are adventures incidental to the Labors.
11. Pausanias attributes the founding of the games to "Heracles the Dactyl," an attendant of the great Cretan goddess. He had nothing to do with the Greek hero Heracles.
12. The attributes of the birds vary with the imagination of individual authors. See D'Arcy W. Thompson, *Glossary of Greek Birds*, 2d ed. (New York: Oxford University Press, 1936), p. 273. The birds are later encountered by the Argonauts on the Island of Ares (see p. 612).
13. There are many folktale elements in the legend, for example, the bridegroom's task, the magician who can understand the speech of animals, and the cure of disease by sympathetic magic (cf. Telephus, pp. 485-486).
14. The Spanish painter Francesco Zurbarán (1598-1664) painted a series of ten canvasses for Philip IV of Spain to be placed in the Palace of Buen Retiro in Madrid (they are all now in the Prado), thus continuing the theme of Heracles' importance to the Spanish monarchy.
15. The killing of Cacus is one of the *parerga* to this labor (see pp. 673-675).
16. The Agathyrsi and Geloni were tribes to the north of Scythia, which was the area between the Danube and the Don.
17. His name means "the house of Osiris." Herodotus points out that the Egyptians did not practice human sacrifice.
18. The combat is described in the pseudo-Hesiodic poem, *The Shield of Heracles*. This Cycnus (whose name in Greek means "swan") is one of several mentioned in various poems.
19. Vergil describes this in the sixth *Eclogue* (6.44): *ut litus Hyla, Hyla omne sonaret* ("so that the shore echoed to the cries of 'Hylas, Hylas.'")
20. There are many variants of the legend of Telephus, about whom both Sophocles and Euripides wrote tragedies.
21. This is the *cornu copiae* (horn of plenty). Amalthea is the name of a goddess of Plenty and of the goat that suckled the infant Zeus. Ovid says that the horn of Achelöus became the cornucopia when the Naiads picked it up and filled it with fruit and flowers.
22. Walter Burkert, *Structure and History in Greek Mythology and Ritual* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1979), p. 94.
23. The "comic" Heracles is well described by Galinsky, Chapter 4.
24. Xenophon, *Memorabilia* 2. 21-34; Cicero, *De Officiis* 1. 118. The parable has been very important in Western art: see E. Panofsky, *Hercules am Scheideweg* (Leipzig, 1930).
25. For further discussion, see L. R. Farnell, *Greek Hero-Cults and Ideas of Immortality* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1921), Chapters 5-7, and G. Karl Galinsky, *The Herakles Theme* (Oxford: Blackwell, 1972). The best discussion is that of Burkert, *Structure and History*. For Heracles in art, see Frank Brommer, *Herakles*, 2 vols. (Darmstadt, Germany: Wissenschaftliche Buchgesellschaft, 1972-1984); vol. 1 has

been translated by Shirley J. Schwarz as *Heracles: The Twelve Labors of the Hero in Ancient Art and Literature* (New Rochelle, NY: Caratzas, 1984). See also Jane Henle, *Greek Myths: A Vase Painter's Notebook* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1973), pp. 231–238.

26. For the different versions of her myth, see J. G. Frazer's notes on pp. 181–182 and 303 in vol. 1 of his edition of *Apollodorus* (Cambridge, MA: Loeb Classical Library, Harvard University Press, 1961 [1921]).

For additional resources related to this chapter, go to www.oup.com/us/morford.

Theseus and the Legends of Attica



Descendants of Erechtheus, fortunate from of old and children of the blessed gods, dwelling in a land that has never been ravaged, feeding on most famous wisdom . . .

—EURIPIDES, *Medea*, 824–829

The Early Kings and Their Legends

Cecrops, Erichthonius, and Erechtheus

The Athenians boasted that they were **autochthonous** (literally, “sprung from the earth”), that is, that they were not descended from any invaders of Attica. They said that Cecrops, their earliest king, had sprung from the earth and was serpent-shaped in the lower half of his body. He has little importance in legend except as the founder of Attica, which he called Cecropia after himself. It was in his time that the contest between Poseidon and Athena for the possession of Attica took place (see pp. 177–178). Poseidon continued to be an important divinity at Athens, and his worship on the Acropolis was closely connected with that of Athena.

Another early figure in Attic mythology is Erichthonius, who was also partly serpent-shaped and (as the element *-chthon-* in his name implies) sprung from the earth. When Hephaestus attempted to violate Athena, his semen fell on the ground, and from it sprang Erichthonius. Athena took him up and put him in a chest, which she gave to the daughters of Cecrops, Pandrosos, Auglauros, and Herse (or only to Pandrosos), forbidding them to look inside. The sisters disobeyed: driven mad by what they saw (either a pair of snakes or Erichthonius